

UNDERCOVER

Dial 'M' for...

They're getting sleeker all the time. And no undercover agent is complete without one. So Agent 001 decides to get himself one of the latest models



Do some research beforehand to figure out which features and options you require and the price you are willing to pay

Austin Powers has one. Nathan Hunt flaunts a couple of sleek ones when he's off on his impossible missions. And James Bond has a new one every time I see him! So I decided it was high time I got myself one as well. A mobile phone, that is. Why, what did you think I was talking about?

Last month, I was on the prowl in some Mumbai suburbs, looking for the perfect little gadget to accompany me on my missions.

I found out pretty soon that Nokia phones are the hot favourites. One of the cheapest and coolest models is the Nokia 3310, known for its compact size and its price tag. This can be anywhere between Rs 7,500 and Rs 13,000, depending on where you buy it. An authorised dealer in Colaba, Mumbai, offered it to me for Rs 11,500. Another vendor promised me, "*Woh-ich maal, bina dabba, sevan five.*" (The same model, without the packaging, for Rs 7,500). When I asked for something similar but cheaper, I was told about the Nokia 3210. This doesn't have the vibration option that the 3310 has, so it costs between Rs 5,500-6,500.

This phone happened to be unavailable at most shops I asked at. Many vendors offered me a substitute. "*Arey! Triumph yaa Alcatel le lo. Sasta padega.*" (Go for Triumph or Alcatel, they'll be cheaper.) Triumph is a mobile service

provider, which also sells unbranded phones under its brand name. Alcatel is known in the market for its looks and features, especially in the latest models such as the Alcatel 701 series. I chanced upon some of these, but they were quite expensive.

Ericsson phones were pricey too, especially the ones I saw in some of the official shops in Andheri. I also saw some smashing Sony and Samsung phones. They were sleek. They were WAP-enabled. Their prices touched Rs 20,000 in the black market. Sigh!

I'd like to say two words about the black market before we go any further—*caveat emptor*. Nokia, Samsung and Ericsson appear to be the most popular trio in the black market, although you'll never hear it from those guys. They just try to sell you whatever they have. So you'll hear a lot of stuff like, this is the latest *maal* (he plans to overcharge you), that he has sold three of these since morning (slow-moving product, maybe defective), or that this is his last piece in stock (wants to dispose of old stock before arrival of a new model).

Another thing that is prevalent is the 'exchange phenomenon'. I kept bumping into people who were trying to exchange their old phones for newer ones. If the deal goes off well, the buyer gets some discount on the new phone he's buying, while the seller gets a phone he can resell as new to an unsuspecting victim.

"*Arey, naya maal hai yaar!*" (It's a new piece) shopkeepers would protest, as I suspiciously opened up the back panel of phones, trying to check whether it was old.

A word of advice: If you are tired of your old phone, you could jazz things up a bit by going in for skins and add-ons made by the company itself. These are available for most phones and cost between Rs 350-550.

One thing's for sure, vendors in the black market are not the best people to ask for recommendations. So do some research beforehand to figure out what type of phone you want, which features and options you require, and the price you're willing to pay. I finally bought the Nokia 3310, so that is one mission accomplished. Next target: a BMW like Agent 007's. ■

What to Look Out for

Be careful about the following points while buying a cell phone:

- Check the cell phone for any damage. Try to see if any scratches are visible on the panel or on the screen of the handset.
- It is probable that you might end up buying a used mobile. The best place to check this is the inside of the mobile where the battery is placed. These parts are not easy to replace unlike the front panel or body, which are easily replaceable.
- Check the battery power. You might be sold a cell phone with inactive batteries or ones that are nearly dead.

- Try dialling through the phone and speaking into it to check for any reception problems.

- If possible, test the various features of the mobile to ensure that the piece is working perfectly.

- Choose a good mobile service provider that has an established setup in your area of residence or work. Also find out about all the schemes being offered by the service provider to pick the one that suits you best.

The final word: buy from authorised dealers. You will not only get a genuine product but also better and more reliable service.

Want to share insights with others on the things to look for when buying a cell phone? Write in to readersletters@jasubhai.com to share your experiences